

The Noble Dhāraṇī Called Samantabhadra

Ārya-Samantabhadra-nāma-dhāraṇī · Toh 699 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་ཀུན་ཏུ་བྱུང་པ་ཞེས་བ་བྱའཁིལ་དུས།

Toh 699 in the Kangyur is a dhāraṇī text known in Sanskrit as the Ārya-Samantabhadra-nāma-dhāraṇī and in Tibetan as Phags pa kun tu bzang po zhes bya ba'i gzungs, meaning in English "The Noble Dhāraṇī Called Samantabhadra." It belongs to the dhāraṇī section of the Kangyur, a class of texts centered on sacred formulas understood to carry powerful protective and spiritual efficacy. The text takes the form of a sūtra, opening with the Buddha residing on Vulture Peak Mountain before the great bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara rises to address him, providing the narrative occasion for the dhāraṇī's revelation. As a dhāraṇī bearing the name of Samantabhadra, one of the foremost bodhisattvas associated with virtuous aspiration and enlightened activity, the text reflects the Mahāyāna tradition's integration of devotional practice and sacred speech within a vast assembly of monks, bodhisattvas, and divine beings.

Here ends the dhāraṇī called "Not Abandoning What Follows."

In the language of India: Ārya-Samantabhadra-nāma-dhāraṇī. In the Tibetan language: The dhāraṇī called "The Noble Samantabhadra."

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear. At one time the Blessed One was dwelling on Vulture Peak Mountain near Rājagṛha, together with a great Saṅgha of eight thousand monks and ninety-nine trillion bodhisattvas, surrounded by many hundreds of thousands of divine sons of the Pure Abodes, who faced him as he taught the Dharma.

Then the great bodhisattva, the noble Avalokiteśvara, rose from his seat, draped his upper robe over one shoulder, placed his right knee on the ground, and with palms joined turned toward the Blessed One, bowed, and spoke to the Blessed One as follows.

Blessed One, today I wish to teach correctly the dhāraṇī of Samantabhadra, which I received from the Tathāgata Candrottama, the Supremely Excellent. The moment this dhāraṇī is heard, those who follow the vehicle of the bodhisattva will become irreversible and will swiftly and perfectly awaken to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening. All karmic obscurations will be cleared away. Great prosperity and abundance will be fully attained. Purity of

body will be attained. Purity of speech will be attained. Purity of mind will be attained. All the vast oceans of perfections will be brought to complete fulfillment. All the oceanic dhāraṇīs will be attained. Every Tathāgata who is seen will be pleased. Blessed One, the moment I myself heard this dhāraṇī, I attained the patient acceptance of the unborn nature of phenomena. I also attained the meditative absorption of courageous progress, the meditative absorption of the precious mudrā, the meditative absorption of the blazing lamp, the meditative absorption of the oceanic mudrā, the meditative absorption of the vajra maṇḍala, the meditative absorption of the inexhaustible basket, the meditative absorption of illusion-like reality, and the meditative absorption that fills and pervades all ten directions — and in this way, Blessed One, meditative absorptions as numerous as the grains of sand in the Ganges River, amounting to ninety-nine trillion, became directly manifest within me. And so it is, Blessed One, that I am now endowed with such mindfulness, endowed with such wisdom, and endowed with such unattached gnosis; and the purpose of seeing, hearing, and serving has been made meaningful. Blessed One, my having heard was meaningful. If hearing this dhāraṇī is meaningful, then may the Blessed One grant permission, and may you also fully present it to these four assemblies.

The Blessed One declared: If you know that the time has come and that sentient beings are ripe, then speak. The Tathāgata has already blessed these four assemblies.

Then the great bodhisattva, the noble Avalokiteśvara, entered meditative absorption in the vajra maṇḍala samādhi in that very instant, that very moment, and spoke this dhāraṇī.

Homage to the Three Jewels. Homage to the great bodhisattva endowed with great compassion, the noble Avalokiteśvara.

Thus it is: khagame khagame, cakṣukhave, śrotrakhave, ghrāṇakhave, jihvākhave, kāyakhave, manakhave, sarakhave, sarakhave, sarakhave, śūnatrakhave, anamitakhave, apraṇihitakhave, samādhikhave, pāramitākhave.

bodhi khave. sara sara sara. sarva buddha adhiṣṭhite. bhara bhara bhara dharma adhiṣṭhite. kala kala kala. saṃgha adhiṣṭhite. namo dvānavatīnāṃ. buddha koṭīnāṃ. adhiṣṭhantu māṃ. catasraḥ parṣado āyur balaṃ ca dadantu. tadyathā. surabhī surabhī. mahā surabhī. muni muni. mahā muni. mati mati mahā mati. namo ratnatrayāya. namas āryāvalokiteśvarāya. bodhisattvāya.

mahāsattvāya. mahākāruṇikāya. samṛdāntu māṃ. samantabhadra dhāraṇī svāhā.

The moment this dhāraṇī was heard, nine hundred and twenty million bodhisattvas attained the meditative absorption known as the heroic advance. Immeasurable bodhisattvas attained various dhāraṇīs.

The ritual method for this dhāraṇī is as follows. Upon rising in the morning, recite it one hundred and eight times. If it is recited twenty-one times, one will behold the noble Avalokiteśvara. When one is in distress, if it is recited mentally seven times, one will be liberated. For all epidemic diseases, recite it into the ear. If one is seized by wind illness, recite it twenty-one times over butter and sesame oil, then anoint with it. For toothache, recite it twenty-one times over a toothstick, then apply it. For earache, boil cotton seeds together with sesame oil, recite seven times, and pour it into the ear using a copper vessel. For headache, apply sesame oil. For abdominal pain, apply as a poultice. For those afflicted by possession, recite one hundred and eight times over a five-coloured thread and tie it around the neck. If one is afflicted by possession of a ḍākinī, recite seven times over sesame oil and anoint all the joints. For all illnesses, apply as a poultice. This is a ritual that requires no preparatory accomplishment practice.

Now, if one desires to behold buddhas and bodhisattvas, to obtain dhāraṇīs and meditative absorptions, to travel by supernatural powers, to render oneself invisible, to anoint the eyes, to practice scrying and the like, then one should arrange a maṇḍala before a stūpa containing relics or before an image, set out one hundred and eight filled vases, erect parasols, victory banners, and pennants, fill trays with various flowers, fumigate with sandalwood, aloewood, and kunduru incense, light one hundred and eight lamps, perform a great offering, put on clean garments observing pure conduct of celibacy, and establish the boundary with these secret mantras of the dhāraṇī:

Namo ratnatrayāya. Namas āryāvalokiteśvarāya bodhisattvāya mahāsattvāya mahākāruṇikāya. Tadyathā. tili bhana dhāmi. mili bhana dhāmi. cili mili bandhāmi. sīmi bandhāmi. May nothing pass beyond my boundary — svāhā.

Recite this twenty-one times fully over water and establish the boundary in the ten directions.

Then, for the dhāraṇī that summons him into presence, first recite the following:

Namo ratnatrayāya. Namas āryāvalokiteśvarāya bodhisattvāya mahāsattvāya mahākāraṇikāya. Tadyathā. cili cili. mili mili. cile li. ehi bhagavān āryāvalokiteśvarāya svāhā.

This is called the heart-essence dhāraṇī, and by it one summons him into presence.

After that, beginning from the eighth day of the waxing moon, recite one hundred and eight times each day until the fifteenth, reciting three times daily, bathing three times daily, and changing garments three times daily. Then on the fifteenth, perform a great offering and recite without limit.

Nevertheless, at midnight Avalokiteśvara, the noble lord, will appear, his body of golden hue, beautifully adorned with the major and minor marks of a great being, radiating from his body ten billion rays of light. The holder of the vidyā mantra must not be frightened upon seeing him but should remain steady; and at the very moment of that vision, a bodhisattva ground will be attained. Dhāraṇīs and meditative absorption will likewise be attained. In the east the Tathāgata Akṣobhya will be seen; in the south, Ratnaketu; in the west, Amitābha; and in the north, the Tathāgata Dundubhisvara. And beyond these, the countless and immeasurable Tathāgatas of all ten directions will be seen in their proper order. After death and passing on from this life, one will be born in the utterly pure buddha-fields, and in every realm one will give joy to the Blessed One, the buddhas.

When the Blessed One had spoken these words, the bodhisattva, the great being, the noble Avalokiteśvara, together with those bodhisattvas, the divine sons of the Pure Abodes, the entire retinue with all its members, and the world with its gods, humans, asuras, and gandharvas, rejoiced and praised what the Blessed One had declared.

The dhāraṇī called "The Noble Samantabhadra" is complete.

This was translated by the Indian preceptors Jinamitra and Dānaśīla, together with the great editor-translator

Translator's Notes

- The Tathāgata name rendered "Candrottama, the Supremely Excellent" translates the Tibetan Zla ba bla ma'i 'od, literally "Light of the Supreme Moon." This appears to be a name meaning something like "Moonlight Supreme" or "Supreme Moonlight," and may correspond to a Sanskrit name such as Candrottama or Uttaracandraprabha; the exact Sanskrit original is not established with certainty.

The mantra syllables are transliterated as they appear in the Tibetan phonetic transcription and are given in approximate reconstructed Sanskrit phonetic form. These are ritual dhāraṇī syllables and their precise Sanskrit spelling may vary across recensions.

The count "ninety-nine trillion" renders the Tibetan *bye ba khrag khrig 'bum phrag dgu bcu rtsa dgu*, a very large enumeration; the exact numerical equivalent in modern terms is approximate.

- The phrase rendered "cotton seeds" translates a Tibetan compound meaning seeds of the cotton plant, used here as a medicinal ingredient for an ear preparation. The identification is standard in Tibetan medical literature.

The term rendered "scrying" translates a Tibetan word literally meaning "distant seeing" or gazing into a medium such as oil to perceive remote or hidden things, a recognized category of siddhi practice in this literature.

The mantra syllables throughout are transliterated as they appear in the Tibetan; they are Sanskrit phonetic approximations and in several cases the underlying Sanskrit is unclear or may represent regional or corrupted forms. No emendation has been made.

- The text breaks off mid-sentence at the end, where the colophon names the Indian paṇḍitas Jinamitra and Dānaśīla and begins to name the Tibetan chief editor-translator (*lotsāwa*), whose name is not given in the supplied passage. Ratnaketu (Tib. *rin chen tog*) is the Tathāgata of the south, and Dundubhisvara (Tib. *rnga sgra*, "drum-sound") is the Tathāgata of the north; these are standard figures in the five-directional buddha-field schema, here presented in a four-direction variant.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.